INTRODUCTION BY SIR JULIAN HUXLEY

IT is APPROPRIATE that this new edition of *The Origin of Species* should appear during the centenary year of Darwin and Wallace's joint paper at the Linnaean Society (July 1, 1858), for it was the bombshell of Alfred Russel Wallace's independent discovery of the principle of natural selection which stimulated Darwin to publish his book. He had been convinced of the mutability of species—what we should now call their evolution—by his experiences on H.M.S. *Beagle* and had been collecting facts bearing on the subject since 1837. But his cautious, and almost diffident, temperament held him back from publishing his conclusions (whose acceptance, he fully realized, would mean a revolution in scientific and general thought) until he could support them with adequate facts. Indeed, it was not until 1842 that he "allowed himself the satisfaction" of writing out a brief thirty-five-page abstract of his theory. Two years later he enlarged this into an "Essay" (though an essay of 230 pages), which is really a first draft of the Origin. However, he showed this only to Lyell and Hooker (and corresponded about his conclusions with Asa Gray). For fifteen further years he went on elaborating his ideas and collecting facts in support of them, with a view to publishing a truly convincing work—a "very big" book, "as perfect as ever I can make it"; and if it had not been for Wallace's moment of inspiration in Ternate, when the idea of natural selection flashed into his fever-stimulated brain, Darwin might well have continued doing so for another fifteen years, and the resultant book might have been unreadably monumental.

As it is, the *Origin* was written in the short space of little over a year, and was the product of a white heat of urgency working on the fruits of twenty-two years' industry and reflection. It is interesting to note that even as Darwin presented the manuscript to his publisher, his characteristic wariness did not leave him. He wrote to John Murray: "Accept your offer. But I feel bound for your sake and my own to say in clearest terms that if after looking over part of the MS you do not think it likely to have a remunerative sale I completely and explicitly free you from your offer."[1]

Such was his comment accompanying the emergence of a truly great book, one which after a century of scientific progress, can still be read with profit by professional biologists.